Sachintha Fernando

PhD Candidate in Economics

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Personal website
Bluesky profile

Research Fields

Primary	Environmental Economics, Applied Econometrics, Causal Inference
Secondary	Open Science, Subjective Well-being

Education

2021 – present	PhD in Economics, **Martin-Luther-Universität Halle-Wittenberg**, Germany Supervisors: Prof. Dr. Christoph Wunder & Prof. Dr. Amelie Wuppermann
2017	MA in Economics, **Uppsala University**, Sweden
2014	BBA in Business Economics, **University of Colombo**, Sri Lanka
2011	Exchange semester, **La Trobe University**, Australia

Research visits

Oct – Dec 2025	Research stay at **Warwick University**, UK Host: Prof. Andrew Oswald
May 2025	Research stay at the **University of Graz**, Austria & the **Wegener Center for Global and Climate Change**, Austria Host: Prof. Hans Manner

Affiliations

2026 – present	Associated PhD Student, ECO-N Research Group, Leipzig
2024 – present	Add-on Fellow, Joachim Herz Stiftung
2023 – present	Member, Berlin Network on Research on Well-being
2020 – present	Research Affiliate, Vérité Research, Sri Lanka

Publications

Zero Fare, Cleaner Air? The Causal Effect of Luxembourg's Free Public Transportation Policy on Transport Emissions (2026) (with Tobias Eibinger) *Environmental and Resource Economics* [link]
Media coverage: *The Economist*; *Verdens Bedste Nyheder*

Rising Waters, Falling Well-being: The Effects of the 2013 East German Flood on Subjective Well-being (forthcoming) (with Katharina Kolb and Christoph Wunder) *Environmental and Resource Economics* [link]

Working Papers

Macro-level Worries in the Energy Transition: Insights from Germany's Coal Phase-out Regions (with Yasmine Bakr and Christoph Wunder) - Invited chapter under review for *Worries, Anxieties and Uncertainties as Social Indicators – Seismographs of Societal Crises* (eds. C. Etter, W. Aschauer & L. Steckermeier), Springer Nature

Are the Effects of Finland's Carbon Tax on Transport Emissions Robust to Donor Pool Composition? (2026) *I4R Discussion Paper No. 317* [link]

Interpolation Bias in Synthetic Controls: Evidence from Carbon Tax Evaluations

The Environmental Effectiveness of Carbon Taxes: A Comparative Case Study of the Nordic Experience (2019) *World Bank Working Paper Series* [link]

Work in Progress

Finite Pool of Worries and Climate Change Concerns

Policy Publications

Sri Lanka's Reversal on Gender Parity: From Global Leader to Global Outlier (2025), Op-Ed, *Daily Mirror* (available online)

Reducing the Gap in Understanding Sri Lanka's Gender Gap (2021), *Vérité Research Insight* (available online)

The Gap between Policy and Practice: A Review of Data Dissemination Practices of Sri Lanka's Department of Census and Statistics (2021), *Vérité Research Policy Note* (available online)

Insights for Mitigating Corruption: Summary Findings (2020), *Vérité Research Policy Note* (available online)

Natural Disaster Insurance Coverage: Solving the Lethargy of Language Policy will Help SMEs Island-wide (2018), *Vérité Research Policy Note* (available online)

Sri Lanka's Economic Competitiveness: A Microcosm of its Politics? (2018), *Vérité Research Insight* (available online)

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, **Martin Luther University Halle-Wittenberg**

Bachelor	Statistics I (SS 2021, 2025) Statistics II (WS 2021/22, 2022/23, 2023/24, 2024/25, 2026/27) Introductory Econometrics (SS 2022)
Master	Applied Microeconometrics (WS 2022/23, 2023/24, 2025/26, 2026/27) Causal Inference (SS 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026) Seminar in Econometrics (WS 2024/25)

Invited Talks

2026	RPTU Kaiserslautern (Germany)
2025	Oxford Wellbeing Research Centre (UK), University of Graz (Austria)
2024	Wageningen University (Netherlands)

Conference Presentations

Upcoming	Leibniz Open Science Day – Nov (Berlin), 12th Annual Conference on the Economics Assessment of European Climate Policies – Nov (Florence), Econometric Society European Winter Meeting – Dec (Warsaw)
2026	AURÖ Workshop for Young Researchers on Environmental and Resource Economics (Leipzig), Scottish Economic Association Annual Conference (Glasgow), EMCC Climate Econometrics Workshop (Aalborg), Verein für Socialpolitik Annual Conference (Innsbruck), Connecting Biodiversity, Climate and Human Behavior (Leipzig)
2025	BeWell Workshop (Berlin), Frontiers in Causal Inference and Machine Learning (Lucca), ISQOLS Annual Conference (Luxembourg), 8th Lindau Nobel Laureate Meeting in Economic Sciences (Lindau)

2024 AURÖ Workshop for Young Researchers on Environmental and Resource Economics (Karlsruhe), Mapping the Effects of Environmental Policies (Hamburg), 6th Applied Economics Workshop (Hannover), What Works Climate Solutions Summit (Berlin), 29th Annual EAERE Conference (Leuven), AERNA Conference (Portugal), Leibniz Open Science Day (Berlin)

2023 28th Annual EAERE Conference (Cyprus), 24th Global Conference on Environmental Taxation (Paris)

2022 9th CGDE Doctoral Workshop (online), STATEC Well-being Conference (Luxembourg), Environmental Protection and Sustainability Forum (Graz)

Honors and Awards

2026 **Best Poster Award**, Connecting Biodiversity, Climate and Human Behavior, Leipzig

2025 Selected participant, **8th Lindau Nobel Laureate Meeting in Economic Sciences**

2025 **insitu Alumni Association Award** (with Katharina Kolb) to organise a PhD workshop

2024 **Joachim Herz Stiftung Add-on Fellowship**

2024 **DAAD STIBET Award**, MLU Halle, for academic achievement and community contribution

2024 **Best Paper Award**, 6th Applied Economics Workshop, Hannover

2023, 2024, 2026 **Women's Advancement Grant**, MLU Halle, for conference participation

2015 – 2017 **Uppsala University IPK Full Tuition Scholarship**

2013 **C.T.C. Gold Medal for Organisational Behaviour**, University of Colombo

2011 **Australian Department of Education Scholarship**, La Trobe University

2011 **Dean's Commendation for Academic Excellence**, La Trobe University

Professional Service

Refereeing Journal of Happiness Studies, Social Indicators Research, Journal of South Asian Development

2022 – present **Coordinator**, Admissions Committee, M.Sc. Economics, MLU Halle

2025 **Co-organiser**, WEM-Halle: PhD Workshop on Empirical Microeconomics, Halle

2025 **Co-organiser**, CGDE Course on Causal Machine Learning (Martin Huber), Halle

2024 – 2025 **Member**, MLU Sustainability Group
Quantified CO_2 emissions from air travel and developed more sustainable business-travel practices

2022 – 2023 **Volunteer Mentor**, Malengo
Mentored a student from Uganda through integration as a new international student in Germany

Selected Workshops and Courses

2026 An Economic Approach to Survey-Based Measurement of Well-Being, DIW Graduate Center, Berlin (Daniel Benjamin)

2026 Tinbergen Institute Econometrics Lectures, Rotterdam (Alberto Abadie)

2025 Environmental Data Collection and Analysis for the Social Sciences, E4C Summer School, Paris

2025 Causal Machine Learning, CGDE, Halle (Martin Huber)

2024 Climate Evidence Accelerator: Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analysis, MCC Berlin

2024 Codechella Madrid: Workshop on Causal Inference (Scott Cunningham)

2024 Environmental Economics, CGDE, Jena (Till Requate)

2023 5th Advanced Summer School in Economics: Causal Inference, Spetses (Jeffrey Wooldridge)

2020 Evaluating Social Programs, MITx (edX)

2019 International Visitor Leadership Program on Women's Global Development and Prosperity, U.S. Department of State

Professional Experience

2017 – 2020 **Team Leader, Economics**, Vérité Research, Colombo, Sri Lanka

- Led quantitative and qualitative research on economic and social issues in Sri Lanka, including survey design and analysis of survey and administrative data
- Managed research projects end to end for clients including USAID, UNICEF, UNDP, ECORYS and CIPE
- Led the economics team: recruitment, performance evaluation, budgeting and staff development
- Wrote grant proposals and concept notes; reviewed and edited policy notes, briefs and reports

2013 – 2015 **Senior Executive, Sustainability**, John Keells Holdings, Colombo, Sri Lanka

- Implemented sustainability standards and conducted environmental audits across the leisure inbound sector and its suppliers
- Managed GRI reporting and ISO 9001, ISO 14001, Carbon Neutral and TourCert certifications
- Employee of the Year, John Keells Leisure Inbound Sector, 2014

Miscellaneous

Software STATA, R, LaTeX, Microsoft Office

Languages Sinhalese (native), English (native), German (B1)

References

Prof. Dr. Christoph Wunder
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Prof. Dr. Amelie Wuppermann
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